In a press conference with the Australian prime minister today, President Biden sharply admonished the Israeli extremists who killed several Palestinians in the West Bank in acts of so-called retaliation. He also called for a humanitarian pause to allow more aid to be shipped to Gaza. Whether Israel will agree remains unclear.

Israelis have been arming themselves in record numbers: some 150,000 applications for gun licenses since October 7, compared with 42 applications in the same period last year. This signals a loss of confidence in the armed forces' ability to respond quickly enough in the face of an emergency. It looks like a frantic response to a situation that is unlikely to repeat itself but which can lead to ominous consequences, such as an intensification of settler violence against the Palestinians in the West Bank.

Russia is taking a clear stand on the side of Iran and Hamas, both at the UN and in talks being held in Moscow. In Israel, Putin is accused of "organizing an axis of terror."

Friday, October 27

While US planes were pounding targets in eastern Syria in retaliation for attacks on American targets, Israel launched a second ground incursion into northern Gaza. No casualties were reported among the raiding troops. A rocket launched from Gaza hit a building in Tel Aviv: four people wounded. The number of Israelis taken hostage on October 7 is now estimated at 229.

These limited incursions seem to be the only ground operations against Gaza for the time being. The lack of confidence between the army and Netanyahu's entourage seems to run as deep as ever. Clearly the PM doesn't want to take responsibility for a ground war that could fail. The hostage issue—which Hamas may be postponing on purpose—is a powerful argument against a hasty incursion, but so are the military uncertainties of tunnel warfare. Notwithstanding the early bluster, it appears that the IDF is